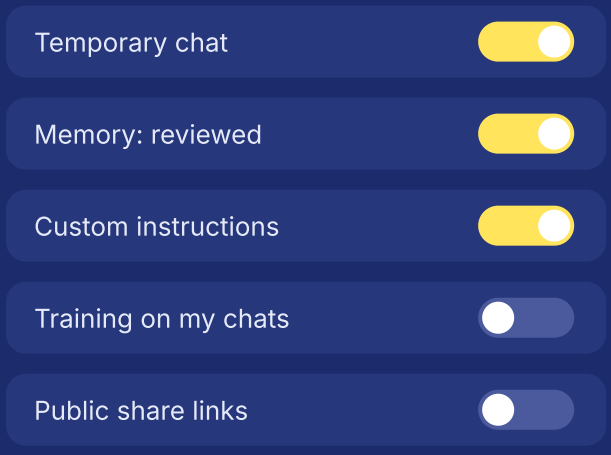
Digital Pathshala
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FREE EBOOK · 2026

THE SETTINGS NOBODY SHOWS YOU

The hidden switches inside ChatGPT, Gemini & Claude

Temporary chats, memory, custom instructions and the privacy settings most people never open — what each one really does, how long your chats are really kept, and the exact settings to use.



53%
of AI users didn't know, or weren't sure, that most chatbots train on chats by default

3 years
how long Gemini can keep a human-reviewed chat — even after you delete it

Includes ready-to-paste custom instructions for 4 professions + a 30-minute setup plan

youtube.com/@DigitalPathshalabyAaryaman

You are using AI with the default settings

Almost everyone does. The defaults are set for the company, not for you: chats are saved, often used for training, remembered across conversations and kept for months. Meanwhile, the features that make AI genuinely smarter about *your* work sit unused, two taps deep in Settings.

~2,000
US adults surveyed by DuckDuckGo about how they use AI
Aug 2026

1 in 3
have told an AI something they wouldn't tell friends, family or a doctor
DuckDuckGo, Aug 2026

75%
didn't know their AI chats can be subpoenaed by law enforcement
DuckDuckGo, Aug 2026

Source: DuckDuckGo survey, reported by 9to5Mac, 25 Aug 2026. India-specific figures are not available; the habits apply everywhere.

What's inside

#	Hidden switch	What you'll walk away with
1	Temporary chats	When to use them + where the button is in each app
2	The memory audit	A prompt that shows everything AI remembers about you
3	Memory hygiene	A save / never-save list and a memory starter pack
4	Custom instructions	Ready-to-paste briefs for 4 professions
5	Tone and personality dials	The anti-flattery instruction
6	The training switch	Where it is in all 3 apps, and what it changes
7	How long chats are really kept	The real retention numbers, in one chart
8	Shared links	A 1-minute check that removes public chats
9	Branches and projects	How to stop one chat from becoming a mess
10	Export and clean-up	A 10-minute monthly routine

Menu names below are as of November 2026. Apps rename settings often; if a name differs, search the app's Settings for the keyword shown.

1 Temporary chats

The clean room: no history, no memory, no training.

Every normal chat is saved, may feed your memory and, by default in many apps, may be used for training. A temporary chat is a blank page: the AI doesn't know who you are, and the conversation disappears from your history. Few people use it, and most who do only think of it as a "privacy mode". It is also the best way to get an **unbiased answer**.

What most people don't know

≤ 30 days

ChatGPT deletes temporary chats from its systems within 30 days. Not shown in history, no memory, not used for training.

OpenAI

72 hours

Gemini keeps temporary chats for up to 72 hours to reply and handle feedback. Not used to personalise or train.

Google, Aug 2025

Ghost icon

Claude's incognito chats aren't saved to history or memory, and are available on the free plan.

Anthropic support

The hidden use: memory and past chats make AI lean toward what it already knows about you (see "Putting your opinion in the question" in our *10 Hidden AI Mistakes* ebook). A temporary chat gives you a **second opinion from an AI that has never met you**.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

ChatGPT

Start a new chat → tap the **Temporary** icon at the top. Look for the dotted-circle icon.

Gemini

Use the **Temporary chat** button next to New chat.

Claude

New chat (outside a project) → click the **ghost icon**, top right.

READY-TO-USE: THE STRANGER'S SECOND OPINION

```
[Temporary chat] I am going to describe a decision. You know nothing
about me, so judge only what I write.
Decision: [describe]
Give me the strongest case against it, the strongest case for it,
and the question I should answer before deciding.
```

STUDENT

Ask a 'silly' question without it shaping future answers.

OFFICE

Test a prompt cleanly before you share it with your team.

BUSINESS

Check a business idea without your past chats biasing the AI.

2 The memory audit

Find out what the AI has quietly learned about you.

All three major chatbots can now remember things about you across chats — sometimes because you asked, often because they decided a detail was useful. Over months this builds a profile: your job, family, health worries, money situation, opinions. Most people have never looked at it.

What most people don't know

Memory is often on by default. Claude's memory is on by default for Free, Pro and Max. Gemini's "past chats" personalisation was switched on by default when it launched in August 2025. ChatGPT has two layers: **saved memories** and **chat history** (insights drawn from past chats).

Anthropic support; Google, 13 Aug 2025; OpenAI memory FAQ.

THE TRAP

In ChatGPT, **deleting a chat does not delete the memories it created**. You have to delete the memory itself. Most people assume the opposite.

OpenAI, "Memory and new controls for ChatGPT".

Switch it on in 60 seconds

ChatGPT

`Settings → Personalization → Manage memories` . Delete items one by one, or clear all.

Gemini

`Settings → Personal context` . Review your memory summary; turn off "past chats" if you prefer.

Claude

`Settings → Your Claude → Manage` next to "Your memory". Edit or delete each topic.

READY-TO-USE: THE MEMORY AUDIT PROMPT

```
List everything you currently remember or have saved about me, grouped
under: work, personal, family, health, money, opinions, preferences.
For each item, say when or how you learned it if you can.
Do not add anything new. Then ask me which items to delete.
```

STUDENT

Remove old exam or college details that now skew answers.

OFFICE

Delete client names or salary figures that slipped into memory.

BUSINESS

Clear outdated prices or stock details before the next season.

3 Memory hygiene

Good memory makes AI smarter. Bad memory makes it wrong and nosy.

Memory isn't good or bad. Saved well, it means you never re-explain your job. Saved carelessly, it means old, wrong or private details colour every answer. The fix is to decide **on purpose** what AI may remember, and to use the per-chat and per-project switches most people don't know exist.

What most people don't know

✓ Worth saving	× Never save
Your role and field ("I'm a CA in Guwahati serving small traders")	Aadhaar, PAN, bank, card or passport numbers
Output preferences (format, length, language level)	Client names, salaries, contracts
Tools you use (Excel 365, TallyPrime, Google Sheets)	Passwords, OTPs, login links
Standing rules ("always cite the section", "say if unsure")	Health details you wouldn't put in an email

Switch memory off for one chat. In Claude, open the + menu before your first message and turn Memory off for that chat only.

Keep projects separate. Each Claude project has its own memory. Turn off "Use account memory" on a project page to fully isolate it (e.g. one per client).

Source: Anthropic support, "Use Claude's chat search and memory to build on previous context".

Switch it on in 60 seconds

Paste the starter pack below once, edit the brackets, and let the AI save it. Then check the memory list (chapter 2) to confirm only these items were saved.

READY-TO-USE: THE MEMORY STARTER PACK

```
Please remember these facts about me and nothing else from this chat:
1. I work as [role] in [field/city]. My readers are [who].
2. I use [tools/versions].
3. Default format: [e.g. short bullet points, then a summary table].
4. Always say 'I'm not sure' instead of guessing, and give sources.
5. Never store client names, ID numbers or money figures I share.
```

STUDENT
Save your syllabus and exam date once; get revision plans that fit.

OFFICE
Save your report format so every summary comes out the same.

BUSINESS
Save your shop's products and tone for consistent offer messages.

4 Custom instructions

A standing brief the AI reads before every chat.

Custom instructions are a box in Settings where you write, once, who you are and how you want answers. The AI applies it to every new conversation. Most people either leave it empty or fill it with "You are a world-class expert...", which research shows doesn't improve accuracy. Put **context, rules and format** there instead.

Where to find it

ChatGPT

`Settings → Personalization` → Custom instructions. Applies to new chats until you change it.

Gemini

`Settings → Personal context` → instructions for Gemini (name varies by version).

Claude

`Settings` → your personal preferences / Your Claude. Projects can have their own instructions too.

Ready-to-paste briefs for 4 professions

STUDENT

```
I am a [class/course] student preparing
for [exam] on [date].
Explain in simple English with one
example. When I ask a question,
give a hint first and the full answer
only if I ask again.
End with 2 practice questions. Say 'not
sure' if you are not sure.
```

TEACHER

```
I teach [subject] to [class] students in
an Indian [board] school.
Outputs: lesson plans, worksheets, MCQs
with answer keys.
Match the [board] syllabus and
difficulty. Mark which questions are
easy / medium / hard. Use Indian names,
rupees and local examples.
```

ACCOUNTANT

```
I am a chartered accountant in India. My
clients are small businesses.
Cite the exact section, rule or
notification for every tax point and
say which financial year it applies to.
If a rule may have changed
after your training data, say so. Never
guess rates or due dates.
```

SHOP OWNER

```
I run a [type] shop in [city]. Customers
are [who].
Write short, friendly messages under 50
words, ready for WhatsApp.
Prices in rupees. Give 2 options each
time. For posters, give the
headline, 1 line of detail and the offer
end date separately.
```

✎ **Three lines to add to any brief** (each fixes a mistake from our *10 Hidden AI Mistakes* ebook): "Say 'I'm not sure' rather than guess." · "Ask me up to 3 questions if my request is unclear." · "Don't just agree with me; point out weak spots."

Persona research: Wharton Generative AI Labs, Prompting Science Report 4, 7 Dec 2025. Settings: OpenAI Academy, "Personalization", Apr 2026.

5 Tone and personality dials

Stop the over-friendly, emoji-heavy, flattering replies.

If AI answers feel long, gushing or full of "Great question!", that's a setting, not a fact of life. Since late 2025 ChatGPT lets you set its personality and fine-tune traits like warmth and enthusiasm. In Gemini and Claude you get the same effect with one line in your instructions.

What most people don't know

ChatGPT, December 2025: new dropdowns for tone and structure — traits such as **Warm** and **Enthusiastic** can be set to More, Less or Default, plus options like more headers and lists or fewer emoji. New presets included **Efficient**, **Nerdy** and **Cynical**, on top of the base styles added with GPT-5.1.

iClarified, 20 Dec 2025, citing OpenAI's announcement.

A sensible "work" setup

Warm	Default	**Enthusiastic**	Less
Headers	More	**Emoji**	Less
Length	Less	**Directness**	More

"Length" and "Directness" aren't ChatGPT dials; set them with the instruction below.

WHY IT MATTERS BEYOND STYLE

Flattery isn't harmless. In April 2025 OpenAI rolled back a ChatGPT update for being "overly supportive but disingenuous". A drier tone makes it easier to notice when the AI is wrong.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

ChatGPT

`Settings → Personalization` → pick a base style (try Efficient), then adjust the trait dropdowns.

Gemini

Paste the instruction below into your Gemini instructions.

Claude

Paste it into your personal preferences, or create a reusable style.

READY-TO-USE: THE ANTI-FLATTERY INSTRUCTION

```
Be direct and concise. No compliments, no 'great question', no emoji.
Lead with the answer, then the reason, then any caveat.
If my idea or work has a weakness, say so clearly in the first line.
Use bullet points only when there are 3 or more parallel items.
```

STUDENT
Get honest feedback on essays instead of praise.

OFFICE
Get reports and emails that are short enough to send.

BUSINESS
Get a straight answer on pricing or a plan, without hype.

6 The training switch

Your chats may be teaching the next model. You decide.

Whether your conversations are used to train future AI models is controlled by one switch per app. On personal plans it is often on unless you change it, and most people never look. Turning it off doesn't make the AI worse for you; it just keeps your conversations out of future training.

What most people don't know

App	Default on personal plans	Where to change it
ChatGPT	Training on chats is **on by default** for Free, Plus and Pro; off by default on business and education plans.	`Settings → Data controls → Improve the model for everyone`
Gemini	With **Keep Activity** on, chats are saved and used to improve Google services, including training. Off: future chats aren't used for training (unless you send feedback).	`myactivity.google.com → Gemini Apps Activity`
Claude	Since Aug 2025, Free, Pro and Max users **choose** whether chats help train Claude. That choice also changes how long data is kept (chapter 7).	`claude.ai/settings/data-privacy-controls`

53%

of AI users didn't know, or weren't sure, that most chatbots train on conversations by default

DuckDuckGo survey, Aug 2026

One more hidden switch: Gemini has a separate control for audio, video and screen-sharing (Gemini Live) being used to improve services. It is **off by default**; check it stays that way.

Google, 13 Aug 2025.

Sources: DeleteMe ChatGPT privacy guide; Google Gemini Apps Privacy Hub; Anthropic, "Updates to Consumer Terms and Privacy Policy", 28 Aug 2025.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

Open each link above on your phone now; it takes under a minute per app. Then ask the AI the question below to confirm you understood the setting.

READY-TO-USE: CHECK WHAT A SETTING REALLY DOES

```
Explain in plain English what your setting '[paste the setting's exact
name and description]' does. What changes for me if I turn it off?
What does NOT change? Is anything already shared affected?
```

STUDENT
Turn it off before pasting notes or assignments you care about.

OFFICE
Turn it off on any personal account you use for work.

BUSINESS
Use a business plan, where training is off by default, for client work.

7 How long chats are really kept

"Deleted" and "off" don't mean gone right away.

Turning a setting off or deleting a chat feels final. It isn't instant, and in some cases it doesn't apply at all. Knowing the real numbers changes what you're willing to type.

What most people don't know

How long each app may keep your chats

Maximum periods stated by each company for personal accounts, as of Nov 2026



The hidden detail: reviewed Gemini chats are disconnected from your account, but **deleting your activity does not delete them**. And "off" still means 72 hours.

Google Gemini Apps Privacy Hub; OpenAI data controls; Anthropic, 28 Aug 2025.

Courts can override deletion. From May 2025 a US court order in the New York Times copyright case forced OpenAI to keep ChatGPT logs that would normally be deleted. It ended on 26 Sept 2025, but chats already preserved stayed preserved. "Delete" is a promise a court can pause.

Engadget, Oct 2025.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

Rule of thumb: if you wouldn't want a stranger to read it in three years, anonymise it first (prompt below) or don't type it.

READY-TO-USE: THE ANONYMISER

```
Before I share details, help me anonymise this text: replace every
name, phone, ID number, account number, address and exact amount with
placeholders like [NAME1], [AMOUNT1]. Keep a key table at the end that
I will keep on my side and delete from this chat.
Text: [paste]
```

STUDENT
Share a real problem from a project without naming people.

OFFICE
Get help with an HR or client case without exposing anyone.

BUSINESS
Analyse a customer complaint without sharing their details.

8 Shared links

The chat you shared once may still be public.

Sharing a chat creates a public web page. Anyone with the link can read it, and links get forwarded. In 2025 an option to make shared chats "discoverable" led to thousands of personal conversations showing up in Google search. Most people have shared links they've completely forgotten.

What most people don't know

~4,500

ChatGPT conversations found through a Google site search in July 2025

Fast Company, via PC Gamer

1 tick-box

'Make this chat discoverable' with small print: 'Allows it to be shown in web searches'

PC Gamer, 4 Aug 2025

Removed

OpenAI pulled the option on 31 Jul 2025: 'too many opportunities... to accidentally share'

OpenAI CISO Dane Stuckey

The option is gone, but **every link you have ever shared still works** until you delete it. A shared chat with your CV, a client draft or a family matter is one forward away from a stranger.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

ChatGPT

`Settings → Data controls → Shared links → Manage`. Delete one by one or all at once. Deleting the chat also kills its link.

Gemini

Check your public links in Gemini's settings (search Settings for "links") and delete old ones.

Claude

Open any chat you shared; unshare it from the share menu. Review shared project content too.

READY-TO-USE: THE PRE-SHARE SCAN

```
Before I share this chat publicly: scan the whole conversation and list
every piece of personal or confidential information in it (names,
numbers, companies, places, health, money). Say which messages they
are in, so I can decide whether to share a cleaned copy instead.
```

STUDENT

Share a study chat with friends without your phone or address.

OFFICE

Share a working chat with a colleague without client details.

BUSINESS

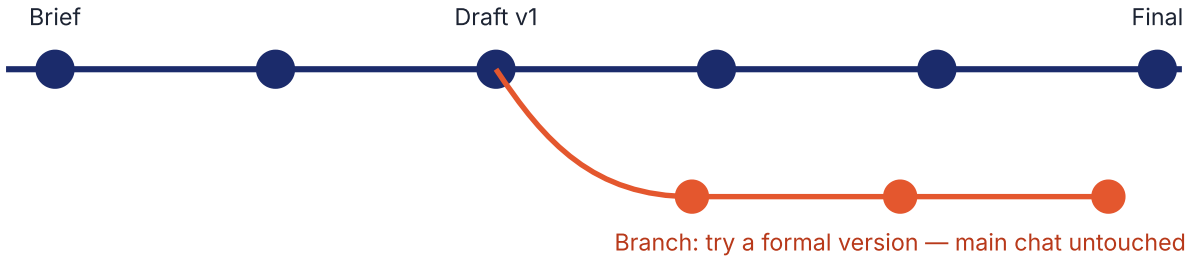
Show a supplier your AI-made plan without your margins.

9 Branches and projects

Stop one chat from becoming a mess.

Long chats make AI worse (our previous ebook showed a 39% average drop when tasks are spread over many turns). Two little-known features keep chats short and clean: **branching**, to try an alternative without spoiling the main thread, and **projects**, to keep each job's files, instructions and memory in its own box.

What most people don't know



Branching (ChatGPT, Sept 2025): hover over any message → more options → **Branch in new chat**. A new chat opens with everything up to that point. Available to logged-in users, including free.

TechRadar, 9 Sep 2025.

Projects: ChatGPT and Claude let you group chats with shared files and instructions. In Claude each project also has **its own memory**, so one client's details never leak into another's.

Anthropic support.

Switch it on in 60 seconds

A simple system: one project per subject, client or business line. Upload the 2–3 files the AI always needs, add the project instructions below, and branch whenever you want to test a different direction.

READY-TO-USE: PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS

```
PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS
This project is for: [subject / client / business line].
Always use the uploaded files as the main source and name the file
and page you used. Key facts: [3-5 facts]. Output format: [format].
If something isn't in the files, say so before using general knowledge.
```

STUDENT
One project per subject, with that syllabus uploaded.

OFFICE
One project per client or report type.

BUSINESS
One project for marketing, one for accounts, one for stock.

10 Export and the monthly clean-up

Your AI history is data. Own it, then trim it.

Months of chats hold real value: prompts that worked, plans, drafts. They also hold risk. You can download everything, keep what's useful in your own files and delete the rest. Almost nobody does, because nobody shows them where.

What most people don't know

ChatGPT export: `Settings → Data controls → Export data`. A download link arrives by email and expires after 24 hours. The ZIP contains a readable chat.html and conversations.json.

DeleteMe ChatGPT privacy guide.

Delete vs archive: deleted ChatGPT chats are scheduled for permanent removal within 30 days. **Archiving only hides a chat**; it is still stored. Gemini activity can be set to auto-delete after 3, 18 or 36 months.

DeleteMe; Google Gemini Apps Privacy Hub.

The 10-minute monthly routine



Switch it on in 60 seconds

Set a monthly phone reminder ("AI clean-up") for the 1st of each month. Then use the prompt below on your exported chats to build a personal prompt library.

READY-TO-USE: BUILD YOUR PROMPT LIBRARY

```
I'm pasting my best old chats below. Extract every prompt that produced
a good result. For each, give: a short name, what it's for, the prompt
with [brackets] for the parts I should change, and one tip to improve
it. Output a table I can save in Google Sheets.
[paste chats]
```

STUDENT
Save your best study prompts before exams.

OFFICE
Turn your best work chats into a reusable team template.

BUSINESS
Keep your best marketing prompts for next festival season.

The settings map

Every switch in this ebook on one page. Tick each one as you set it.

Switch	ChatGPT	Gemini	Claude	✔
Temporary chat	Temporary icon, top of a new chat	Temporary chat button by New chat	Ghost icon, top right	☐
Review memory	Personalization → Manage memories	Settings → Personal context	Your Claude → Manage memory	☐
Memory off	Personalization → Memory	Personal context → past chats	Your Claude → Memory from chats; + menu per chat	☐
Custom instructions	Personalization → Custom instructions	Personal context → instructions	Personal preferences; project instructions	☐
Tone	Personalization → base style + traits	Via instructions	Via preferences / styles	☐
Training	Data controls → Improve the model for everyone	myactivity.google.com → Keep Activity	settings/data-privacy-controls	☐
Auto-delete	Delete chats (removed ≤ 30 days)	Auto-delete: 3 / 18 / 36 months	Delete chats	☐
Shared links	Data controls → Shared links → Manage	Search Settings for "links"	Unshare from each chat	☐
Export	Data controls → Export data	Google Takeout	Settings → Privacy → Export	☐

The 30-minute setup plan

MINUTES 0–10 · PROTECT

- ✔ Decide on the training switch in each app
- ✔ Delete old shared links
- ✔ Run the memory audit prompt

MINUTES 10–20 · PERSONALISE

- ✔ Paste your profession's brief (page 6)
- ✔ Add the anti-flattery instruction
- ✔ Save the memory starter pack

MINUTES 20–30 · ORGANISE

- ✔ Create 2–3 projects for your main work
- ✔ Try one temporary chat and one branch
- ✔ Set the monthly clean-up reminder

Menu names as of November 2026; apps rename settings often. Gemini's Google Takeout and Claude's export locations follow each company's standard data-download pages.

Before you close this ebook

★ **The one-line summary:** use a temporary chat for anything private or any question where you want an unbiased answer; use memory, instructions and projects for everything you repeat; and spend 10 minutes a month cleaning up.

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10 Hidden AI Mistakes Nobody Warns You About (2026)

The research on why "Are you sure?" backfires, why long chats get worse, why AI detectors flag honest students, and 10 copy-paste fixes. It pairs with this ebook: that one fixes *how you ask*, this one fixes *how your AI is set up*.

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Sources

Checked on 12 November 2026. Settings and policies change; the date of each source is shown.

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A note on accuracy

Retention periods are the maximums each company states for personal accounts. Business, education and API plans have different rules, usually stricter in your favour. Where a company doesn't publish a number (for example, how long Claude keeps incognito chats), this ebook doesn't guess one.